
Harrison Birtwistle

BORN 1934, BRITISH

Born in Accrington, Lancashire, Birtwistle grew up in the world of military and brass bands, and the sounds of brass and percussion have often been to the fore in his music, which is characteristically energetic and often violent (although it also has moments of humor and lyrical beauty). Initially, he excelled as a clarinetist, but in his mid-twenties he gave up playing to concentrate entirely on composing. Birtwistle is renowned particularly as the leading British opera composer of his generation, although it was not until *Gawain* (1991) that he actually titled a piece “opera”: his first work in the field, for example, *Punch and Judy* (1967), was called a “comical tragedy or tragical comedy.” In addition to works for the stage (often based on mythological subjects), he has also written orchestral, chamber, and solo instrumental music, as well as choral and solo vocal pieces.

KEY WORKS: *Punch and Judy*, 1967; *Earth Dances*, 1986; *Gawain*, 1991; *The Minotaur*, 2008

Steve Reich